Philosophy 25B: Modern Philosophy

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Princess Elisabeth's Objection to Descartes' Interactionist Dualism

Princess Elisabeth of Bohemia was an influential figure in the 17th century who made various contributions to areas of metaphysics, physics, and political philosophy. She additionally contributed to philosophy surrounding the nature of mind and was one of Descartes' earliest and influential critics of his theory of substance dualism. In her correspondence to Descartes (1643), Elisabeth acknowledges that minds can cause action in bodies, but she raises objections to how this interaction could occur in the first place under Descartes' view that minds and bodies are composed of different substances. I seek to reconstruct Elisabeth's objection through the premises that support it, and then elaborate further on what I suppose to be the strongest reply by Descartes to her claim. First, I will define Descartes' substance dualism in order to provide context for Elisabeth's objections. Next, I will explain Elisabeth's definition of interaction. Then, I will reconstruct Elisabeth's objection against Descartes' mind-body interaction by explaining the premises it was built on and what Elisabeth concludes from these premises. Following this, I will discuss Descartes' reply to Elisabeth's objection. Finally, I will end by explaining why Descartes' reply finds little success in supporting his dualist views due to the nature of the question itself.

In his Sixth Meditation, Descartes defines the real distinction between mind and body. He does this through a series of premises that culminate in the conclusion that the nature of the mind is essentially different from the nature of the body – in other words, they are of different kinds of substances. The minds are composed of thinking immaterial substance whereas bodies are

composed of extended material substance (Descartes, Meditations on First Philosophy: Meditation Six). This conclusion stems from the premise that a mind existing in the absence of a body is conceivable and thus the mind must not be a mode of the body but rather its own substance. Descartes continues on to draw the idea that a human is composed of two substances, a mind and a body, and within these substances there lies a system where physicality is causally related to both the physical and the mental, and mentality is causally related to both the mental and the physical. In other words, physical action can cause physical motion, such as a car hitting a person and knocking them over, as well as mental states, such as the pain of the person felt from the impact. Furthermore, mental states can cause other mental states, such as the mental state of belief that there is chocolate cake in the refrigerator inducing a mental state of desire for chocolate cake, as well as physical action, such as the aforementioned desire for chocolate cake causing the body to go to the refrigerator and consume said cake.

According to Elisabeth there are three ways in which something gets moved. The first way is self-propulsion (Elisabeth's correspondence to Descartes, 6 May 1643). This way falls under the condition that there was already movement in the causing body, and this movement relies on properties of the body such as current speed and mass. The second way is being pushed by something. This is the impulse that Elisabeth describes, the moment of contact of two bodies. The third way is the motion determined by nature and shape of the pushing thing. This includes properties such as the angle, speed, and mass of the pushing thing. The first two conditions involve contact within a physical space, and the third condition requires extension in order to have shape.

Based on her understanding of motion, Elisabeth arrives at the conclusion that a mind under Descartes' definition cannot be involved in any of the cases that result in motion

(Elisabeth to Descartes, 6 May 1643). In her correspondence with Descartes, Elisabeth provides the following argument in order to establish her objection against dualist interactionism:

1. In order for a body to move, the moving body must be propelled in some manner.
2. The ways in which a body can be propelled are dependent on physical contact or extension.
3. Minds are immaterial and thus do not have extension and cannot make physical contact.

C: Minds cannot move bodies.

This objection presented by Elisabeth is valid: If X can only influence Y when X has certain attributes, and X lacks said attributes, then X cannot influence Y. The first two premises stem from Elisabeth's understanding of physics. Furthermore, according to Descartes' definitions of minds and bodies, the third premise is sound under the application of Descartes' definitions. Therefore, Elisabeth's objection is sound as well as valid. Elisabeth agrees with Descartes on the principle that minds must be able to influence bodies, as this principle is necessary in explaining how actions are performed by the body due to intentions. What she challenges, however, is precisely how this interaction could take place under Descartes' system of definitions. She asserts that if the mind can make the body perform such actions, then the mind must be interacting with the body in one of the three ways she defined.

Descartes responds at first by proposing an example for Elisabeth's further edification. He puts forth the example of a rock being drawn downwards toward Earth by its weight. The movement of the rock does not occur through the real contact of one surface against another, but rather a causal interaction of the rock's weight moving the rock (Descartes to Elisabeth, 21 May 1643). Descartes did not have access to the theories of gravitational pull that are present in the contemporary, and he does concede that he does not subscribe to this view of weight. He uses

this example as a means to attempt to explain the nature of mind-body interactionism as best he can using notions that were commonplace at the time. Descartes then also introduces another reply to Elisabeth's objection. He replies that one cannot apply the same causal principles of material things to immaterial things. Descartes asserts that there are different kinds of causation, and it is a mistake to think that all causation must be reflective of how material things affect other material things. He claims that minds affect bodies in a much different way than how bodies affect bodies.

Descartes' replies fall short of supporting his dualist theory. In analyzing his first rebuttal, even without knowledge of how gravity interacts with matter, it is easy to point out that weight is not a separate entity from the rock. Therefore, the interaction between a substance and its mode, demonstrated by the rock and its weight, cannot be used to make a case for interaction between a substance and another substance, or mind and body. Perhaps it could support the mind as a mode of the body, but Descartes had already established in his Sixth Meditation that the mind is its own substance via a modal argument. This entire assessment, however, is irrelevant because it completely misses the point Descartes is making. The nature in question of the interaction between mind and body has no similarity to any other relationship present in the world, and Descartes knows he is set up for failure to try to come up with an example that would help Elisabeth understand. Descartes attempted to use the accepted concept of "real qualities" at the time, even though he himself did not support that theory, and ended up confusing Elisabeth further (Descarte to Elisabeth, 21 May 1643). Unfortunately for him, the case of minds and bodies does not seem at all similar to the case of objects and weight.

In his second rebuttal, Descartes' claim of different kinds of causation is highly unsatisfactory, as he does not thoroughly explain what these other kinds are aside from them

being between minds and bodies. It comes as no surprise, then, when Elisabeth thinks that minds and bodies as defined by Descartes are simply too different to interact. She proposes an alternative that she finds more conceivable: that minds and bodies are both material. This solves the interaction problem in a more convincing manner to Elisabeth, although it undermines major portions of Descartes' metaphysics (Elisabeth to Descartes, 10 June 1643). This concession by Elisabeth reveals that she herself doesn't even know what kind of explanation she wants. It seems primarily that she wants a mechanical explanation, which Descartes cannot provide given the nature of immaterial minds, as mechanics strictly applies to material things. The point that Descartes is trying to make throughout his letters is that humans have a primitive understanding of this interaction, and that is all that will ever be able to be achieved (Descartes to Elisabeth, 21 May 1643). The interaction cannot be further explained, so Elisabeth's demand for details will forever remain unsatiated. Descartes does not give a satisfactory explanation because it is, in his view, impossible to provide.